



and character before a record-setting attendance of more than 1.2 million spectators during his clinical 6-3, 7-6 (4), 6-3 final triumph on the 120th birthday of the Australian Open.

Sinner broke (or equalled) several records himself, such as joining Roger Federer, Novak Djokovic (twice), Ivan Lendl, and John McEnroe in winning three consecutive Grand Slam titles on hard courts. He became the eighth man in the Open Era, which began in 1968, to win his first three or more Major title matches (following Jimmy Connors, Bjorn Borg, Stefan Edberg, Gustavo Kuerten, Federer, Stan Wawrinka, and Carlos Alcaraz). A paragon of high-level consistency, Sinner also faced no break points in the final of a Major, a feat achieved only by Federer at the 2003 Wimbledon and Rafael Nadal at the 2017 US Open.

Alexander (Sascha) Zverev enjoyed a deceptive 4-2 match edge over Sinner in their rivalry going into the 2025 AO final. Sinner began emerging as a superstar at the 2023 Davis Cup final, where he whipped Djokovic. Soon after, the Italian won his first Major at the Australian Open. In August 2024, the much-improved Sinner, then No. 1, beat Zverev in a close three-setter on the Cincinnati hard courts. When they met in this Melbourne final, Zverev's No. 2 ranking was misleading because the Paris Olympics — where Djokovic outplayed Alcaraz for the gold medal — unjustifiably awarded no ranking points.

The most pertinent statistic was Zverev's horrendous 1-12 career record against top-5 opponents at Grand Slam events. Tellingly, the 6'6" German caved in his two previous chances to win a Major. He blew a two-set advantage against Dominic Thiem in the 2020 US Open final and suffered the same bitter fate against Alcaraz in the 2024 Roland Garros final. Conversely, Sinner racked up 47 wins in his first 50 matches as world No. 1, equalling the record set by Borg and Connors.

Any hope Zverev had of capturing his first Major after years of frustration faded early in Sinner's decisive victory. Relaxed and confident, Sinner opened the final with an ace and easily held serve (at love), as he would throughout the match.

Zverev staved off two break points in the fifth game, but two games later, Sinner converted his sixth break point when Zverev erred on a backhand volley. "Despite awesome serving, Zverev still lost this game," noted *ESPN* analyst McEnroe. Not even getting 83 per cent of his rocket first serves in saved him from losing the first set, 6-3.